

The Glorious King of Tantras: The Tantra of the Glorious King of Wisdom

Śrī Jñānarāja Tantra Rāja · Toh 398 · Derge Kangyur

དཔལ་ལ་ཤེས་རལ་པོའི་རྒྱལ་པོ་ཀློང་པོ་

Toh 398 in the Kangyur is a tantric scripture known in Sanskrit as the Śrī Jñānarāja Tantra Rāja and in Tibetan as the Dpal ye shes rgyal po'i rgyud kyi rgyal po, rendered in English as The Glorious King of Tantras, the Tantra of the Glorious King of Wisdom. It belongs to the class of Buddhist tantras and concerns the nature of self-awareness beyond duality, the primordially unborn character of reality, and the profound equivalence of saṃsāra and nirvāṇa, themes conveyed through verse teachings addressed to the Buddha and oriented toward the role of the guru in guiding practitioners to liberation. The text opens with homage to the Glorious Great Bliss, signaling its orientation toward the Mahāyoga or higher tantric traditions in which bliss and non-dual awareness are central soteriological categories. As Toh 398, it is preserved among the tantric works of the Kangyur, the Tibetan collection of canonical texts attributed to the Buddha himself.

Requested and established in definitive form.

In the language of India: Śrī Jñānarāja Tantra Rāja. In the language of Tibet: The Glorious King of Tantras, the Tantra of the Glorious King of Wisdom. Homage to the Glorious Great Bliss.

O buddha, O buddha!

O buddha, how excellent are your deeds!

So that all sentient beings

may attain nirvāṇa,

complete faith and diligent effort,

and enter in the wake of the guru.

In self-awareness (ātman) that is beyond duality,

those who grasp at other-awareness as two are deluded.

In what is primordially unborn and unestablished,

those who grasp at birth and establishment are deluded.

In things whose taste has become equal,

those who grasp at inferior and superior are deluded.

When the thorough understanding of saṃsāra itself

is declared to be nirvāṇa,

those who conceptually distinguish buddha from sentient being are deluded.
In what is spontaneously accomplished by intrinsic nature,
those who think it arises through cause and condition are deluded.
In what is free from signs and conventional designations,
those who make it an object for the intellect are deluded.
In abiding in the Middle Way free from extremes,
those who grasp at permanence or annihilation are deluded.
In what transcends the domain of what can be known or expressed,
those who grasp at self and what belongs to self are deluded.
In emptiness devoid of all conceptuality regarding things, characteristics, and
so forth,
those who subsequently grasp at things are deluded.
In what is itself beyond duality,
those who grasp at two truths are deluded.
In the higher and lower vehicles of the Dharma
that tame the many kinds of trainees to be tamed,
those who superimpose or denigrate are deluded.
In the various deluded states of sentient beings
such as the karmic maturation of actions and so forth,
those who denigrate through their views are deluded.
In self-awareness primordially luminous,
those who wish to grasp at vajra-holders
with body-color, hand-emblems, and the like are deluded.

Delusion and the ground of delusion:
attachment, and great attachment.

When the ground of delusion is transcended beyond delusion,
the Blessed One is great attachment.

Aversion and great aversion:
likewise, the Blessed One is aversion.

Delusion and great delusion:
likewise, the Blessed One is delusion.

By this one is certainly liberated.

Abandoning this, there is no liberation through anything else.

Lords who are deities, gurus as brothers —

lords who are simply yogins together:

as a general summary of the vehicles, apart from that,

the dull portions of ordinary people are one in eight.
These are the cause for attaining self-awareness.
Therefore, above all, preserve the sacred pledges.
The distinction of the fruit arises as self-awareness.

O protector, O buddha —
if attachment is distinguished in that way,
what then is its essential nature?
The same applies to aversion and so forth.

Vajra-essence, great compassion —
listen well and hold it in mind.

Not knowing the cause and result of karma and karmic maturation — that is delusion.

The agitation of body and mind through and through — that is aversion,
through the three gates.

Fully aroused, directed toward the jewel's ultimate point — that is attachment,
the arising of the seed.

From what essential nature empowerment and so forth are known —
attachment and the rest are established as great.

On what the essential nature of self-awareness rests:
the antidote that abandons the lower
is knowing the essential nature as illusion,
and gathering the sense faculties — that is the method.

For the higher, becoming a cause for arising,
moreover it has become great:
acting for the benefit of others,
others becoming inspired by it,
the many who are not inspired abandoning it,
not being overwhelmed by afflictions in general,
specifically not being overwhelmed by attachment, aversion, and so forth,
no conceptuality whatsoever arising in the lower,
abandoning afflictions in general and in particular,
being certain that it is the antidote,
and not even a hair-tip of affliction arising —
two of these are similar to the higher.

These twelve — great attachment — are spoken of as the Blessed One;

Those who, without having realized the profound view and conduct, engage in mantra recitation and chanting and so forth — their efforts are pointless and fruitless. They must seek the supreme oral instructions from a genuine holy guru.

At that time, he rejoiced in and took delight in the meaning of the tantra.

This was translated by the Indian master Gāyadhara and the translator Dge—

- The verse "ॐ नमो भगवते वासुदेवाय ॥ गुरुः भगवन्महेश्वरः ॥ गुरुः भगवन्महेश्वरः ॥ गुरुः भगवन्महेश्वरः ॥" is syntactically compact and the doctrinal referent obscure; the rendering "lords who are deities, gurus as brothers — lords who are simply yogins together: as a general summary of the vehicles, apart from that, the dull portions of ordinary people are one in eight" attempts faithfulness to the literal structure but this passage may belong to a technical Vajrayāna classification system requiring commentary to fully decode. The number "one in eight" may refer to a fraction or a specific doctrinal enumeration.

- The final sentence breaks off mid-phrase, as the Tibetan colophon is incomplete at this point, cutting off after the translator's name begins. This is a standard translation colophon naming the Indian paṇḍita Gāyadhara (a well-known eleventh-century scholar who worked extensively in Tibet) and a Tibetan lotsāwa whose name is not fully given in the supplied passage.

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consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.